

## **Developmental History Paper**

Annabelle P.J. Woody

University of South Carolina: College of Social Work

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Dr. Alicia Anderson-Brown

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## **Developmental History Paper**

For this paper I interviewed someone born in the early seventies, who grew up in Fountain Inn, South Carolina. The interviewee, raised in a conservative Judeo-Christian household as the eldest of three children, experienced a lower-middle-class upbringing shaped by a strong emphasis on faith, family, and responsibility. Both parents worked, and their role as foster caregivers introduced him to diverse relational dynamics from an early age. Significant milestones in his life include graduating college, marrying, becoming a parent, being ordained as a minister, and building a successful business after losing a full-time job. He identifies his spouse, faith, and community as key sources of support throughout his life. Notable challenges include navigating financial constraints in childhood, coping with the death of loved ones, and balancing professional aspirations with client demands. Currently, he is adapting to the transition of an empty nest while embracing the joys and responsibilities of grandparenthood. His strengths include strong leadership, resilience, and a belief in second chances, all of which have shaped his personal and professional growth (C. Woody, personal communication, December 6, 2024). The interviewee's developmental history reflects a life shaped by significant milestones, challenges, and a network of personal and environmental influences. His early experiences established a foundation for his strong sense of responsibility and adaptability—traits that he considers central to his later accomplishments, such as graduating college, starting a family, and building a thriving business.

## **Theories and Framework**

Applying Erikson's Psychosocial Development Theory, as found in chapter five of our textbook, key stages of his life can be understood as milestones of growth and

resolution (Rogers, 2019). For instance, his journey through identity vs. role confusion was marked by a slowly growing independence and eventually finding purpose in ministry and expanding his view of what that role entails. His transition into fatherhood—and later grandparenthood—aligns with generativity vs. stagnation, as he emphasized nurturing the next generation and adapting to a mentorship role, but later having “empty nest syndrome” and not knowing what to do with himself.

Bronfenbrenner’s Ecological Systems Theory, found in chapter two, provides further insight by contextualizing his development within overlapping systems (Rogers, 2019). His family and church—microsystem—offer(ed) stability and moral grounding, while societal values and economic constraints—macrosystem—influenced his life choices. Over time, interactions between these systems—such as the interplay of family dynamics and career shifts—shaped his responses to challenges like job loss and parenting. Additionally, transitions like empty nesting and grandparenthood have emphasized the importance of time and change in development. Both of these frameworks collectively illuminate how the interviewee’s strengths, such as leadership, resilience, and faith, were cultivated through personal determination and a supportive environment. At the same time, they highlight areas where stress and role transitions posed challenges, underscoring the intricate balance between individual agency and systemic influences in human development.

### **Discrepancies Between Frameworks and Development**

While Erikson’s Psychosocial Development Theory and Bronfenbrenner’s Ecological Systems Theory offer valuable insights into the interviewee’s developmental journey, certain aspects remain unexplained by these frameworks. Erikson’s stage-based approach

assumes a linear resolution of psychosocial conflicts, yet the interviewee's sense of identity and purpose evolved dynamically over time, and were reinforced later in adulthood through ordination and ongoing mentorship roles, rather than being resolved in adolescence. Similarly, Bronfenbrenner's focus on external systems does not fully account for internal emotional processes, such as coping with grief or reconciling artistic vision with client demands, as experienced by the interviewee. Moreover, the frameworks overlook the transformative role of adversity, such as the personal growth spurred by experiences—such as job loss, and the immediate leadership required during life events—such as a suspected school shooting while he was substitute-teaching. These nuances suggest that while the theories provide a strong foundation, they cannot entirely encompass the complexity of individual experiences, particularly those shaped by faith, creativity, and resilience.

### **Childhood Social Ecology**

The interviewee's upbringing in a lower-middle-class household and exposure to the foster care system reflects elements of social ecology discussed by Lopez et al. (2021) in *The Social Ecology of Childhood and Early Life Adversity*. While financial constraints and the presence of foster siblings could have posed early life stressors, the protective factors within his social environment—namely, a strong faith foundation and a cohesive family unit—likely buffered against these adversities. These supports align with the article's findings that resilient family structures and community ties mitigate the long-term effects of childhood adversity. Moreover, his ability to navigate challenges later in life, such as job loss and professional setbacks, demonstrates the potential for early social ecology to shape adaptive stress responses. This resilience underscores the importance of fostering strong

support networks, a theme central to both the interviewee's life and the article's conclusions.

### **Job-loss**

The interviewee's experience of losing a full-time job aligns with the findings of Navarro-Abal et al. (2018) regarding the psychological challenges of unemployment and the importance of coping strategies. Despite the initial stress and uncertainty, the interviewee demonstrated resilience by reframing the loss as an opportunity to grow his business and be more involved with his children. His strong social support network, particularly his spouse's encouragement and practical assistance, mirrors the study's emphasis on the critical role of external support systems in navigating job loss. Additionally, his faith and long-term goal orientation likely contributed to his ability to adapt and thrive, underscoring the interplay of personal and social resources in overcoming adversity. This journey reflects broader themes of resilience and adaptability in the face of life transitions, reinforcing the importance of social and psychological support highlighted in both the study and the interview.

The interviewee's response to job loss also aligns with the findings of Mandal et al. (2011), demonstrating how subjective expectations play a critical role in shaping mental health outcomes. Despite the initial stress of unemployment, the interviewee approached the situation with optimism, viewing the job loss as a catalyst for personal and professional growth. His confidence in building his business and the support of his spouse helped him avoid the depressive outcomes associated with negative expectations. This resilience underscores the importance of maintaining a future-oriented perspective, as highlighted by the study. Additionally, his faith and goal-oriented mindset likely bolstered his positive

outlook, reinforcing themes of adaptability and the role of subjective expectations in navigating life transitions discussed in previous paragraphs.

### **Faith and Development**

The interviewee's strong faith background resonates with the findings of Abo-Zena and Rana (2020), showcasing how religion shapes resilience and positive development. Growing up in a Judeo-Christian household and participating actively in church, he developed a foundation of moral values, community support, and a sense of purpose. These influences likely played a pivotal role in helping him navigate challenges such as financial constraints in childhood, job loss, and grief over losing loved ones. His ability to view adversity as part of a larger plan and rely on faith for guidance aligns with the article's emphasis on religion as a resource within ecological systems. This connection reinforces the interviewee's reliance on both personal strengths and external supports, highlighting the interplay between his religious beliefs and broader developmental factors discussed in previous paragraphs.

## References

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